



KMS: I always tell my colleagues that when you're hiring for any position, please assess the potential of a woman and the experience of a man, because men are automatic choices since they come with experience.

If it's a woman, she doesn't have that kind of experience, but she could be very bright. How do you make sure that you assess potential? Most people can answer technical questions, but then you have to have a gut feel to know who a problem solver is, who has got the ability to think on their feet, who is going to be resourceful, who is going to really think about the business differently. Even when I interview people, I don't ask them technical questions, I want to understand how they think about situations, how they think about solving problems.

SZ: Are you still looking for acquisitions of the kind you made?

KMS: Right now, I'm trying to make sure that the integration and transition is seamless. To make such a big acquisition is not easy. Viatris was the front-facing partner, it was a known brand, but Biocon was not because we were doing the research and manufacturing.

We were doing a lot of the heavy lifting. But the value of the business was largely attributable to Viatris. So,

we were only getting 30% of the value of the total business for doing a lot of the heavy lifting and I think Viatris was really getting 70% of the value for front-ending.

But there came a time when Viatris themselves came to me saying maybe it's time to cull-out the biosimilars business from our general business and create a JV and if you can park all your assets into that JV and we will park all the commercial assets, then maybe we have a 50-50 joint venture. I've never believed in joint ventures. I've always believed in creating my own business, my own name.

SZ: Why is that?

KMS: I believe that creating value as a single entity is much greater than having a JV where neither of them really get the true value of the brand. So, I just felt that I would rather buy them out than to get into a JV.

SK: What's been the challenge in integration and getting people in the time of artificial intelligence (AI)?

KMS: Let me answer that in two ways: one is that fortunately there were no overlapping functions between our two organisations, we were very good at research and development (R&D) and manufacturing, and they were very good at commercialising products. To that